

Georgia - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Consensus top-five and national-title caliber.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 3 (1513 points) · SEC media 1st (88 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 4
Returning production	67% (No. 9) overall · Off. 63% (No. 31) · Def. 71% (No. 5)
Primer power rating	+26.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	9.9 wins · most likely 10-2
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar elite overall quality: the 2026 roster returns more of its high-leverage defensive core than the raw NFL departure list suggests, while offense shifts from a veteran receiver group toward Stockton/Frazier/OL continuity and a less-settled pass-catching hierarchy.
Confidence	High

2026 identity: Georgia still wants to run the ball from multiple/heavy personnel under Mike Bobo, using QB Gunner Stockton, RB Nate Frazier and a decorated interior/left-side OL core while the wideouts sort themselves out. Defensively, Smart/Schumann can build around S KJ Bolden, CB Ellis Robinson IV, ILB Raylen Wilson, DL Elijah Griffin and EDGE Gabe Harris Jr., aiming for more havoc without losing elite explosive-play prevention.

Bottom line: Georgia is one of the safest national-title contenders; the question is whether receiver/OL turnover and a few availability issues keep the offense from matching an elite defense against a demanding SEC schedule.

Beats expectations if: A receiver separates from the crowded group, Stockton converts Georgia's strong efficiency base into more explosive passing, and the defense's veteran stars raise havoc while the secondary stays healthy.

Disappoints if: The receiver room never finds a high-end separator, Dowdell remains unavailable and the RT/secondary health competitions linger, forcing Georgia to play too many close games while replacing multiple drafted front-seven and secondary contributors.

Five things to remember

- 1 Returning production:** Georgia is No. 3 in the AP poll, No. 4 in SP+ and No. 1 in the SEC media poll, with 67% overall returning production (No. 9).
- 2 ? QB question:** QB Gunner Stockton is the established starting quarterback; RB Nate Frazier, C/OL Drew Bobo and OL Earnest Greene III give the offense a proven spine even though the WR pecking order remains open.
- 3 ★ Preseason recognition:** The defense returns unusually high-end star power: S KJ Bolden and CB Ellis Robinson IV are preseason first-team national selections, ILB Raylen Wilson is an AP second-team linebacker, and defensive returning production is 71% (No. 5).
- 4 NFL departures:** The 2025 roster sent eight players into the NFL Draft plus six additional UDFA/free-agent/tryout opportunities; Georgia's continuity is strong, but the composition turnover is still substantial.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** The schedule is 7/10 by the schedule difficulty scale and gets especially demanding after the bye: Florida (neutral), at Ole Miss, Missouri and at South Carolina are four straight SP+ top-24 opponents.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	12-2 (8-2 SEC)	● Excellent
Scoring	32.1 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	402.4 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	182.1 YPG · 4.4 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	7.39 YPA · 25 TD / 7 INT	● Very good
Third downs	43.6%	● Very good
Scoring defense	17.6 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	298.0 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	81.5 YPG · 2.9 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	216.5 YPG · 6.60 YPA · 14 TD allowed	● Good / above average

Georgia’s 12-2 season again leaned on a high-end defense: scoring defense was No. 10, total defense No. 14 and rush defense No. 4.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+9.34 · No. 10	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.174 · No. 13	● Elite
Off. success rate	47.8% · No. 19	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	11.8% · No. 77	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	14.0% · No. 52	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+10.62 · No. 7	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.131 · No. 17	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	38.1% · No. 31	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	7.1% · No. 4	● Elite
Havoc created	15.0% · No. 81	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: Georgia’s 2025 advanced profile was championship-quality on both sides, but with two revealing non-elite traits: offensive explosiveness ranked only No. 77 despite top-20 efficiency, and defensive havoc created ranked No. 81 despite No. 7 opponent-adjusted defense and No. 4 explosive prevention.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Kirby Smart - Returning head coach; program identity and defensive oversight remain stable	● ↔ Keeps program identity and defensive oversight stable with no leadership transition.
OC / offensive play-caller	Mike Bobo - Returning OC/QBs; is the offensive play-caller	● ↔ Mike Bobo's return keeps the offensive system and primary play-calling structure intact.
DC / defensive play-caller	Glenn Schumann - Returning DC/ILBs; is the defensive play-caller	● ↔ Glenn Schumann's return preserves defensive system leadership and game-day play-calling continuity.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ WR Isiah Canion	Georgia Tech	● ↔ A major WR candidate with spring praise, but the fall hierarchy remains open and no receiver had separated by Aug.
♦ RB Dante Dowdell	Kentucky	● ↔ Adds the physical RB profile Georgia sought, but the offseason accident and lack of a return timetable make the impact availability-dependent.

Out	To	Loss
WR Zachariah Branch	NFL (Atlanta), Round 3, No. 79	● ↓ The 2025 leading high-volume receiver/return weapon leaves after 81 catches, 811 yards and six touchdowns.
OL Monroe Freeling	NFL (Carolina), Round 1, No. 19	● ↓ A 13-start tackle and first-round pick leaves a high-leverage protection vacancy.
TE Oscar Delp	NFL (New Orleans), Round 3, No. 73	● ↓ A 34-career-start tight end departs, increasing the importance of TE Lawson Luckie's expanded role.
WR Colbie Young / WR Noah Thomas / WR Dillon Bell	Colbie Young: NFL (Cincinnati), Round 5, No. 140; Noah Thomas: NFL (Cincinnati); Dillon Bell: NFL (Minnesota)	● ↓ Multiple veteran receivers leave with Branch, making the 2026 pecking-order uncertainty a true composition change rather than a minor depth shuffle.

Offensive net: ● ↔ elite ceiling with a less proven pass-catching structure. QB Gunner Stockton, RB Nate Frazier, C/OL Drew Bobo and OL Earnest Greene III provide continuity, but the receiver and tackle losses create real replacement work.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ S Khalil Barnes	Clemson	● ↔ Adds an experienced, preseason-recognized safety option to a deep but still sorting secondary.

Out	To	Loss
ILB CJ Allen	NFL (Indianapolis), Round 2, No. 53	● ↓ The 2025 team-leading tackler and second-round pick is a major loss from the middle of the defense.
DL Christen Miller	NFL (New Orleans), Round 2, No. 42	● ↓ Major defensive-line starter/pressure contributor leaves in Round 2.
DB Daylen Everette	NFL (Pittsburgh), Round 3, No. 85	● ↓ Captain/50-tackle defensive back leaves in Round 3, creating meaningful secondary replacement volume.
S Joenel Aguero	Ole Miss	● ↓ A 12-start, 39-tackle safety transfers out, another significant subtraction from the back end.

Defensive net: ● ↔ still elite, with unusually strong returning star power offsetting another large professional/transfer departure class. The main risk is not talent but replacing experienced front-seven and secondary snaps without losing efficiency.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Bobo-called, run-oriented multiple/heavy-personnel offense built around Stockton, Frazier and matchup creation.	Excellent 2025 down-to-down efficiency, a stable starting QB and decorated OL/TE/RB pieces.	Replacing Branch and several veteran receivers while trying to improve an explosive-play rate that ranked only No. 77.
Defense	Smart/Schumann defense emphasizing streamlined communication, depth, run defense and more havoc.	Elite secondary/linebacker talent; No. 7 opponent-adjusted defense and No. 4 explosive prevention in 2025.	Replacing major front-seven/secondary departures while improving a No. 81 havoc-created rate.
Special teams	Model-projected elite special teams with an established kicker but turnover at punter/long snapper.	Established kicker plus an SP+ No. 3 special-teams signal.	Punter and long-snapper turnover reduce operational continuity.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	QB Gunner Stockton anchors a similar projection
RB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Nate Frazier anchors a similar projection
WR	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Isiah Canion arrives while WR Zachariah Branch departs in a worse outlook
TE	● B+	● ↔	High	TE Lawson Luckie anchors a similar projection
OL	● A-	● ↓	Medium-high	C/OL Drew Bobo and OL Earnest Greene III anchor a line replacing first-round OT Monroe Freeling
DL/Edge	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	DL Christen Miller departs, but returning front talent keeps the projection similar
LB	● A	● ↔	High	ILB Raylen Wilson anchors a similar projection
Secondary	● A	● ↔	Medium-high	S KJ Bolden and CB Ellis Robinson IV headline a similar projection
Special teams	● A-	● ↔	Medium	Woodring's proven role/recognition and SP+ No. 3 special-teams signal.
Coaching	● A+	● ↔	High	Staff and play-calling continuity support stability
Overall	● A+	● ↔	High	Consensus top-five and national-title caliber

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ KJ Bolden	S	● National star / defensive centerpiece	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Thorpe	Georgia's safety leader and one of the most decorated defenders in the country; central to preserving the defense's elite explosive prevention.
★ Ellis Robinson IV	CB	● National star	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 2nd team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Bednarik · Thorpe · Walter Camp POY	Elite returning corner gives Georgia a premium coverage anchor while multiple 2025 DB contributors depart.
Gunner Stockton	QB	● High-end conference starter	SEC Coaches 3rd team · SEC Media 3rd team · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Established starter whose certainty is a major reason the national-title evaluation is stable despite skill-position turnover.
Nate Frazier	RB	● High-end conference starter	SEC Coaches 2nd team · SEC Media 2nd team · Maxwell	Lead back in the run-first offensive structure; his stability matters more if Dowdell remains unavailable.
Drew Bobo	C/OL	● National-level OL anchor	AP 2nd team · Walter Camp 2nd team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Outland · Rimington	The interior line's most decorated anchor and a key stabilizer while tackle/backup-center roles sort out.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Earnest Greene III	OL	● High-end conference tackle	SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Outland	Returning major OL piece whose experience offsets the first-round loss of OL Monroe Freeling.
Raylen Wilson	ILB	● National-level linebacker	AP 2nd team · SEC Coaches 2nd team · SEC Media 2nd team · Bednarik · Butkus	Premium returning linebacker tasked with helping replace ILB CJ Allen's team-leading 2025 tackle production.
Lawson Luckie	TE	● High-end conference starter	SEC Coaches 2nd team · SEC Media 2nd team · Mackey	The primary returning tight-end piece after TE Oscar Delp's draft departure and an important fit in Georgia's heavy-personnel offense.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Championship-level but not the nation's most extreme schedule. Georgia gets two home warmups, then a dense SEC slate with repeated ranked-quality opponents and several meaningful road/neutral tests.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 26
Hardest stretch	Florida (neutral) → at Ole Miss → Missouri → at South Carolina. Coming directly after the bye, all four are SP+ top-24 opponents and two are away from Athens.
Swing games	at Alabama, vs Oklahoma, Florida (neutral), at Ole Miss
Advantage	The first two games are home against Tennessee State and Western Kentucky, and the only bye arrives immediately before the Florida/Ole Miss/Missouri/South Carolina run.
Expected	9.9 wins · most likely 10-2
Floor / ceiling	8-4 / 12-0

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Georgia deserves national-title pricing; the betting question is whether a number already assumes the unresolved WR/RT/RB issues are solved.
Back them when	Georgia can control the line, QB Gunner Stockton can stay on schedule, and S KJ Bolden/CB Ellis Robinson IV/ILB Raylen Wilson can deny explosives.
Fade/pass when	The price assumes explosive passing before a receiver separates, RB Dante Dowdell or secondary availability reduces depth, or an elite front can attack the unsettled RT/backup-center setup.
Key monitor	WR pecking order, RB Dante Dowdell return timetable, right tackle/backup-center configuration, secondary availability, third-down RB role
Week 1 baseline	vs. Tennessee State: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Georgia -47.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Georgia enters 2026 with championship-level quality, a settled QB in QB Gunner Stockton and premium defensive anchors. The offense still has to replace major receiver and tackle production, so its explosive ceiling is less certain than the defense's floor.

A 10-2 baseline fits the roster and model strength, but Georgia will rarely be cheap. The best preseason stance is to respect the title profile while demanding price value until the new pass-catching hierarchy and protection edges settle.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp update](#) · [roster roles](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [current update](#) · [current update 2](#)

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